SOCIOECONOMIC FALSE BELIEF #51 · WORK AND CALLING

“My work only matters to God if it's ministry.”

✦ ✦ ✦

Where it often comes from

Many believers hear more about missionaries and pastors than about plumbers, nurses, and clerks. Over time, a divide forms in the mind: spiritual work counts, ordinary work is just a paycheck. People in everyday jobs may feel their days are secondary, or even wasted.

What Scripture teaches

Paul writes, “Whatever you do, work at it with your whole being, for the Lord and not for men… It is the Lord Christ you are serving.” He also writes, “So whether you eat or drink or whatever you do, do it all to the glory of God.” God put man in the garden “to cultivate and keep it,” so work was part of creation before the fall. Solomon wrote, “Whatever you find to do with your hands, do it with all your might.” All honest work can be done for God.

> *“Whatever you do, work at it with your whole being, for the Lord and not for men, because you know that you will receive an inheritance from the Lord as your reward. It is the Lord Christ you are serving”* (Colossians 3:23–24).

Also see

> “So whether you eat or drink or whatever you do, do it all to the glory of God” (1 Corinthians 10:31).

> “Then the LORD God took the man and placed him in the Garden of Eden to cultivate and keep it” (Genesis 2:15).

> “Whatever you find to do with your hands, do it with all your might, for in Sheol, where you are going, there is no work or planning or knowledge or wisdom” (Ecclesiastes 9:10).

> “And to aspire to live quietly, to attend to your own matters, and to work with your own hands, as we instructed you. Then you will behave properly toward outsiders, without being dependent on anyone” (1 Thessalonians 4:11–12).

Common self-statements

- My job is just a paycheck.
- Only church work really counts.
- God does not care about my daily tasks.
- I am wasting my life in an ordinary job.
- Real servants of God are in ministry.
- My work is not spiritual.

Common logical errors

- Dichotomous thinking: Dividing work into sacred and secular.
- Discounting the positive: Dismissing the good my work does.
- Should statements: Insisting that I should be in ministry.
- Labeling: Calling my job “just a job.”

Challenging questions

- Where did I learn to rank work as sacred or ordinary?
- Whom does my work serve, and how?
- What does Colossians 3:23 say about who my real boss is?
- How can I bring honesty, kindness, and excellence to my job?
- What did Adam's work in the garden say about work?
- How would I treat my work if I believed God saw it?

Truth summary

> All honest work can be done for the Lord. My job matters to God because I matter to Him and because the work serves people. I can do my work as worship, with honesty, care, and excellence.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Occupation/Job/Work
- Servant
- Gifts, Spiritual
- Fruitful
- Witness

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Unemployment
- Thinking, Healthy

Listen: Overcoming Depression

> Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Is He Worthy — Andrew Peterson
Honest recognition of a broken world can lead to hope in Christ's final restoration.

Voice of Truth — Casting Crowns
Test accusing or frightening messages against God's truth.

All Things New — Steven Curtis Chapman
God's renewing work offers hope beyond failure, decay, and loss.

Great Is Thy Faithfulness — CeCe Winans
This classic hymn recalls God's steady mercy through changing circumstances.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "My work only matters to God if it's ministry"

✦ ✦ ✦

Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"My work only matters to God if it's ministry." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ Who does my work serve?
- ☐ Who is my real boss?
- ☐ How can I work with excellence?
- ☐ Where did I learn to rank work?
- ☐ How can I show Christ at work?
- ☐ What is one task I can dedicate today?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ I serve the Lord Christ in my work.
- ☐ Whatever I do can glorify God.
- ☐ Work began in the garden.
- ☐ Ordinary work is honorable.
- ☐ My work serves people.
- ☐ God sees my faithfulness.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ Colossians 3:23–24
  "Whatever you do, work at it with your whole being, for the Lord and not for men, because you know that you will receive an inheritance from the Lord as your reward. It is the Lord Christ you are serving."
- ☐ 1 Corinthians 10:31
  "So whether you eat or drink or whatever you do, do it all to the glory of God."
- ☐ Genesis 2:15
  "Then the LORD God took the man and placed him in the Garden of Eden to cultivate and keep it."

A verse I found myself: _____

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

Practicing the Truth

✦ ✦ ✦

5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- ☐ Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- ☐ Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- ☐ Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- ☐ Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- ☐ Work as worship: Each day, note one task you did for the Lord and how.
- ☐ My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, Colossians 3:23–24 becomes: "Sarah can write: "I am serving the Lord Christ in my work.""
- ☐ Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- ☐ Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- ☐ Reading: The "Occupation/Job/Work" topic in Pearls.
- ☐ Listening: The Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

This card is educational and is not financial or legal advice. Choose steps you can do safely. If you are without food, housing, or safety, contact your church, a trusted advisor, or local assistance services.

- ☐ Name who your work serves. Write the people who benefit from what you do.
- ☐ Dedicate your day. Pray each morning, "Lord, this work is for You."
- ☐ Show Christ at work. Choose one act of kindness or honesty today.
- ☐ Memorize Colossians 3:23. Put it where you see it at work.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "My work only matters to God if it's ministry": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	Work as worship
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~My work only matters to God if it's ministry.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Lord, thank You for work. Help me see my daily tasks as service to You. Let me work with honesty, kindness, and care, and let the people I serve see Your love. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.

SOCIOECONOMIC FALSE BELIEF #52 · WORK AND CALLING

“God can't use me without a good job.”

✦ ✦ ✦

Where it often comes from

Job titles, income, and influence can seem like the qualifications for being used by God. When a layoff, health problem, or limited education leaves us without a “good job,” we may believe our usefulness has expired. Churches can reinforce this when leadership roles go mainly to the successful.

What Scripture teaches

When the leaders saw the boldness of Peter and John, “realized that they were unschooled, ordinary men, they marveled and took note that these men had been with Jesus.” Gideon said, “my clan is the weakest in Manasseh, and I am the youngest in my father’s house.” Amos said, “I was not a prophet… I was a herdsman and a tender of sycamore-fig trees.” God said to Moses, “Who gave man his mouth?” God does not need a résumé. He uses willing people.

> *“When they saw the boldness of Peter and John and realized that they were unschooled, ordinary men, they marveled and took note that these men had been with Jesus”* (Acts 4:13).

Also see

> “‘Please, my Lord,’ Gideon replied, ‘how can I save Israel? Indeed, my clan is the weakest in Manasseh, and I am the youngest in my father’s house.’” (Judges 6:15).

> “‘I was not a prophet,’ Amos replied, ‘nor was I the son of a prophet; rather, I was a herdsman and a tender of sycamore-fig trees.’” (Amos 7:14).

> “And the LORD said to him, ‘Who gave man his mouth? Or who makes the mute or the deaf, the sighted or the blind? Is it not I, the LORD?’” (Exodus 4:11).

> “But God chose the foolish things of the world to shame the wise; God chose the weak things of the world to shame the strong” (1 Corinthians 1:27).

Common self-statements

- I have nothing to offer without a good job.
- God uses people with status.
- I am too ordinary to be useful.
- I need a better résumé first.
- Others are better suited for His work.
- My unemployment makes me useless to Him.

Common logical errors

- Labeling: Calling myself useless because of my job status.
- Discounting the positive: Overlooking gifts and character I already have.
- All-or-nothing thinking: Believing I am either useful with a good job or useless.
- Comparison: Measuring my usefulness against successful people.

Challenging questions

- Whom did God use in Scripture who had no status?
- What gifts, kindness, and wisdom do I have that no job title gives?
- Who around me could I help this week?
- What does “with Jesus” mean for my usefulness?
- What would I tell a friend without a job who felt this way?
- What is one thing God might use me for today?

Truth summary

> God does not need my job title. He uses people who have been with Jesus, ordinary and willing. I can serve right where I am today with the gifts He gave me.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Gifts, Spiritual
- Servant
- Self-Esteem, Low
- Witness
- Occupation/Job/Work

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Unemployment
- Self-Esteem, Low

Listen: Overcoming Depression

> Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Who Am I — Casting Crowns
Being known and cared for by God rests on His love rather than personal importance.

Dear Younger Me — MercyMe
Past wounds and choices do not have to become a person’s permanent identity.

Greater — MercyMe
God’s presence and grace challenge shame and the need to win everyone’s approval.

Blessed Assurance — Larry Ford and Lillie Knauls with Gaither
This classic hymn celebrates belonging to Christ and resting in His salvation.

Each morning ask: “If I truly believed God’s truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?”

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "God can't use me without a good job"

✦ ✦ ✦

Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"God can't use me without a good job." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ Whom did God use who had no status?
- ☐ What gifts do I have?
- ☐ Whom can I help?
- ☐ What qualified Peter and John?
- ☐ What would I tell a friend?
- ☐ How might God use me today?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ God uses ordinary people.
- ☐ Being with Jesus is the qualification.
- ☐ He used the weakest and youngest.
- ☐ My gifts do not depend on a job.
- ☐ I can serve today.
- ☐ He made me as I am for His purposes.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ **Acts 4:13**
  "When they saw the boldness of Peter and John and realized that they were unschooled, ordinary men, they marveled and took note that these men had been with Jesus."
- ☐ **Judges 6:15**
  "'Please, my Lord,' Gideon replied, 'how can I save Israel? Indeed, my clan is the weakest in Manasseh, and I am the youngest in my father's house.'"
- ☐ **Exodus 4:11**
  "And the LORD said to him, 'Who gave man his mouth? Or who makes the mute or the deaf, the sighted or the blind? Is it not I, the LORD?'"

A verse I found myself: _____

Practicing the Truth

✦ ✦ ✦

5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- [ ] Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- [ ] Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- [ ] Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- [ ] Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- [ ] Used today: Each day, write one way you helped or encouraged someone.
- [ ] My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, Acts 4:13 becomes: "Sarah can write: "God can use ordinary people who have been with Jesus, and that includes me.""
- [ ] Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- [ ] Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- [ ] Reading: The "Gifts, Spiritual" topic in Pearls.
- [ ] Listening: The Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

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- [ ] List your gifts. Write ten qualities and abilities that are not job titles.
- [ ] Serve someone. Do one act of kindness or help this week.
- [ ] Read Acts 4:1–22. Notice who God used.
- [ ] Tell a friend. Share how you feel about your work situation and ask for perspective.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "God can't use me without a good job": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	A way I was used
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~God can't use me without a good job.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Father, You use ordinary people. Free me from believing I must have status to serve You. Show me someone to help today and use me where I am. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.

SOCIOECONOMIC FALSE BELIEF #53 · WORK AND CALLING

“Rest is laziness, even when God commands it.”

✦ ✦ ✦

Where it often comes from

Families that prized hard work may have called rest “wasting time.” Cultures that celebrate busyness reinforce it. Even people who know the Sabbath is a command may feel guilty for taking it, especially when money is tight and there seems to be more to do than hours to do it.

What Scripture teaches

God told Israel, “Remember the Sabbath day by keeping it holy. Six days you shall labor and do all your work, but the seventh day is a Sabbath to the LORD your God.” Jesus said, “The Sabbath was made for man, not man for the Sabbath.” The psalmist says, “In vain you rise early and stay up late, toiling for bread to eat—for He gives sleep to His beloved.” Jesus invites, “Come to Me, all you who are weary and burdened, and I will give you rest,” and told His disciples, “Come with Me privately to a solitary place, and let us rest for a while.” Rest is obedience.

> *“Then Jesus declared, ‘The Sabbath was made for man, not man for the Sabbath.’”* (Mark 2:27).

Also see

> “Remember the Sabbath day by keeping it holy. Six days you shall labor and do all your work, but the seventh day is a Sabbath to the LORD your God, on which you must not do any work—neither you, nor your son or daughter, nor your manservant or maidservant or livestock, nor the foreigner within your gates” (Exodus 20:8–10).

> “In vain you rise early and stay up late, toiling for bread to eat— for He gives sleep to His beloved” (Psalm 127:2).

> “Come to Me, all you who are weary and burdened, and I will give you rest” (Matthew 11:28).

> “And He said to them, ‘Come with Me privately to a solitary place, and let us rest for a while.’ For many people were coming and going, and they did not even have time to eat” (Mark 6:31).

Common self-statements

- I cannot afford to rest.
- Resting is lazy.
- There is always more to do.
- If I rest, I will fall behind.
- Others work harder than I do.
- I have to earn my rest.

Common logical errors

- Should statements: Insisting that I should always be working.
- All-or-nothing thinking: Seeing myself as either productive or lazy.
- Emotional reasoning: Feeling guilty and concluding that rest is wrong.
- Catastrophizing: Imagining that a day off will lead to ruin.

Challenging questions

- Who taught me that rest is laziness?

- What did God do on the seventh day, and what does He command?
- What did Jesus do when He was tired?
- What does Psalm 127:2 say about God giving sleep to His beloved?
- What happens to my work, health, and family when I never rest?
- What is one way I could rest this week?

Truth summary

> Rest is a gift and a command from God, not laziness. The Sabbath was made for me. I can rest without guilt, trusting that God provides while I sleep and cares for what I cannot finish.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Tired
- Sleep Problems
- Laziness
- Obedience
- Trust

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Weak/Tired
- Prayer

Listen: Overcoming Anxiety

> Overcoming Anxiety · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 18 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Just Be Held — Casting Crowns
God's care remains when control, strength, or explanations run out.

The God Who Stays — Matthew West
God's faithful presence challenges the expectation of rejection and abandonment.

Oh My Soul — Casting Crowns
Honest distress can coexist with faith and hope in God.

Great Is Thy Faithfulness — CeCe Winans
This classic hymn recalls God's steady mercy through changing circumstances.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "Rest is laziness, even when God commands it"

✦ ✦ ✦

Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"Rest is laziness, even when God commands it." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ Who taught me that rest is laziness?
- ☐ What did God command?
- ☐ What did Jesus do when tired?
- ☐ What happens when I never rest?
- ☐ What can I trust God with?
- ☐ When will I rest this week?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ The Sabbath was made for me.
- ☐ God gives sleep to His beloved.
- ☐ Jesus invites the weary to rest.
- ☐ Rest is obedience, not laziness.
- ☐ I can trust God with unfinished work.
- ☐ Rest helps me serve better.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ Mark 2:27
  "Then Jesus declared, 'The Sabbath was made for man, not man for the Sabbath.'"
- ☐ Psalm 127:2
  "In vain you rise early and stay up late, toiling for bread to eat— for He gives sleep to His beloved."
- ☐ Matthew 11:28
  "Come to Me, all you who are weary and burdened, and I will give you rest."

A verse I found myself: _____

Practicing the Truth

✦ ✦ ✦

5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- [ ] Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- [ ] Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- [ ] Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- [ ] Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- [ ] Rest received: Each week, write one way you rested and how it felt.
- [ ] My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, Mark 2:27 becomes: "Sarah can write: "The Sabbath was made for me, so I can rest without guilt.""
- [ ] Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- [ ] Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- [ ] Reading: The "Tired" topic in Pearls.
- [ ] Listening: The Overcoming Anxiety audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

This card is educational and is not financial or legal advice. Choose steps you can do safely. If you are without food, housing, or safety, contact your church, a trusted advisor, or local assistance services.

- [ ] Name the message. Write who taught you that rest is lazy.
- [ ] Plan a Sabbath. Choose a block of time each week to rest, pray, and enjoy.
- [ ] Sleep enough. Set a bedtime and protect it.
- [ ] Pray Psalm 127:2. Thank God for sleep as a gift.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "Rest is laziness, even when God commands it": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	Rest received
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~Rest is laziness, even when God commands it.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Lord, You commanded rest and gave it as a gift. Free me from guilt about stopping. Teach me to trust You with what I leave undone and to receive rest as Your love. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.

SOCIOECONOMIC FALSE BELIEF #54 · WORK AND CALLING

“If I'm not productive, I'm wasting the life God gave me.”

✦ ✦ ✦

Where it often comes from

Productivity can become a moral standard. Lists, goals, and income can turn into a daily scoreboard. Every unproductive hour can seem like a failure, and illness, caregiving, unemployment, or old age can feel like waste. Many of us were praised when we achieved and ignored when we rested.

What Scripture teaches

The psalmist prays, “So teach us to number our days, that we may present a heart of wisdom.” Paul says, “We are God’s workmanship, created in Christ Jesus to do good works, which God prepared in advance as our way of life,” so God prepares the works. When Martha was busy and worried, Jesus said, “only one thing is necessary. Mary has chosen the good portion.” God also says, “Be still and know that I am God.” A well-lived life is measured by wisdom, love, and presence, not output.

> *“So teach us to number our days, that we may present a heart of wisdom”* (Psalm 90:12).

Also see

> “For we are God’s workmanship, created in Christ Jesus to do good works, which God prepared in advance as our way of life” (Ephesians 2:10).

> “‘Martha, Martha,’ the Lord replied, ‘you are worried and upset about many things. But only one thing is necessary. Mary has chosen the good portion, and it will not be taken away from her.’” (Luke 10:41–42).

> “‘Be still and know that I am God; I will be exalted among the nations, I will be exalted over the earth.’” (Psalm 46:10).

> “He has shown you, O man, what is good. And what does the LORD require of you but to act justly, to love mercy, and to walk humbly with your God?” (Micah 6:8).

Common self-statements

- Every unproductive minute is a waste.
- I must always accomplish something.
- Time off is a failure.
- Being sick means I am useless.
- I am only valuable when I produce.
- I will regret all the time I wasted.

Common logical errors

- Should statements: Insisting that I must always be productive.
- All-or-nothing thinking: Seeing time as either productive or wasted.
- Labeling: Calling myself a waster.
- Magnification: Treating rest or slow seasons as huge failures.

Challenging questions

- Who taught me to measure life by output?

- What do Scripture's verses on wisdom say about how to number my days?
- What did Jesus say about Mary's choice?
- What things in life matter that cannot be measured, such as love, prayer, or presence?
- What is God doing in seasons when I cannot produce?
- What would a good day look like that is not measured by tasks?

Truth summary

> My life is not measured by output. God prepared good works for me, and He also calls me to be still, to love, and to sit at His feet. A season of rest or slowness is not wasted in His hands.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Meditation
- Thinking, Healthy
- Wisdom
- Tired
- God, First/Only

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Thinking, Healthy
- Weak/Tired

Listen: Overcoming Depression

> Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Already There — Casting Crowns
God's perspective extends beyond what we can currently understand.

Oh My Soul — Casting Crowns
Honest distress can coexist with faith and hope in God.

Just Be Held — Casting Crowns
God's care remains when control, strength, or explanations run out.

Great Is Thy Faithfulness — CeCe Winans
This classic hymn recalls God's steady mercy through changing circumstances.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "If I'm not productive, I'm wasting the life God gave me"

✦ ✦ ✦

Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"If I'm not productive, I'm wasting the life God gave me." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ Who taught me to measure life by output?
- ☐ What matters that cannot be measured?
- ☐ What was Mary's good portion?
- ☐ What does stillness teach me?
- ☐ What would a good day look like?
- ☐ What is God doing in slow seasons?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ God numbers my days with wisdom.
- ☐ He prepared good works for me.
- ☐ Sitting at His feet is the good portion.
- ☐ Stillness is part of faith.
- ☐ Love and presence matter.
- ☐ No season is wasted in His hands.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ **Psalm 90:12**
  "So teach us to number our days, that we may present a heart of wisdom."
- ☐ **Ephesians 2:10**
  "For we are God's workmanship, created in Christ Jesus to do good works, which God prepared in advance as our way of life."
- ☐ **Luke 10:41–42**
  "'Martha, Martha,' the Lord replied, 'you are worried and upset about many things. But only one thing is necessary. Mary has chosen the good portion, and it will not be taken away from her.'"

A verse I found myself: _____

Practicing the Truth

✦ ✦ ✦

5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- ☐ Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- ☐ Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- ☐ Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- ☐ Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- ☐ The good portion: Each day, write one unmeasured thing that mattered, such as a conversation, a prayer, or a moment outdoors.
- ☐ My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, Psalm 90:12 becomes: "Sarah can write: "Teach me to number my days, that I may have a heart of wisdom.""
- ☐ Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- ☐ Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- ☐ Reading: The "Wisdom" topic in Pearls.
- ☐ Listening: The Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

This card is educational and is not financial or legal advice. Choose steps you can do safely. If you are without food, housing, or safety, contact your church, a trusted advisor, or local assistance services.

- ☐ Write your scoreboard. List how you measure a good day and who taught it.
- ☐ Add a non-task item. Put time with God or a loved one on your list.
- ☐ Sit still. Spend 10 minutes in quiet with Psalm 46:10.
- ☐ Review your week by love. Note moments of love and kindness, not just tasks.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "If I'm not productive, I'm wasting the life God gave me": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	What mattered
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~If I'm not productive, I'm wasting the life God gave me.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Lord, teach me to number my days with wisdom. Free me from measuring my worth by output. Help me sit at Your feet, do the works You prepared, and trust that no season is wasted. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.

SOCIOECONOMIC FALSE BELIEF #55 · WORK AND CALLING

“God values me for what I accomplish.”

✦ ✦ ✦

Where it often comes from

Children who are praised mostly for grades, achievements, or helpfulness often conclude that love is earned. In adulthood this becomes a quiet belief: God is pleased when I produce and disappointed when I do not. Church can reinforce it when service is applauded more than simple presence.

What Scripture teaches

Paul writes, “For it is by grace you have been saved through faith, and this not from yourselves; it is the gift of God, not by works, so that no one can boast.” “He saved us, not by the righteous deeds we had done, but according to His mercy.” “God proves His love for us in this: While we were still sinners, Christ died for us.” When the disciples rejoiced in their success, Jesus said, “rejoice that your names are written in heaven.” Zephaniah says the LORD “will rejoice over you with gladness; He will quiet you with His love.” God’s delight in us is not a wage.

> *“For it is by grace you have been saved through faith, and this not from yourselves; it is the gift of God, not by works, so that no one can boast”* (Ephesians 2:8–9).

Also see

> “He saved us, not by the righteous deeds we had done, but according to His mercy, through the washing of new birth and renewal by the Holy Spirit” (Titus 3:5).

> “But God proves His love for us in this: While we were still sinners, Christ died for us” (Romans 5:8).

> “Nevertheless, do not rejoice that the spirits submit to you, but rejoice that your names are written in heaven” (Luke 10:20).

> “The LORD your God is among you; He is mighty to save. He will rejoice over you with gladness; He will quiet you with His love; He will rejoice over you with singing” (Zephaniah 3:17).

Common self-statements

- God is pleased only when I achieve.
- I have to earn His approval.
- When I fail, He is disappointed.
- My worth goes up and down with my results.
- I must keep proving myself.
- I am loved for what I do.

Common logical errors

- Emotional reasoning: Feeling worthless when I fail and concluding God sees me that way.
- All-or-nothing thinking: Believing I am either accomplished and loved, or failing and unloved.
- Should statements: Insisting that I must earn God’s love.
- Mind reading: Assuming God is disappointed in me.

Challenging questions

- When was I praised for what I did rather than who I was?

- What does “not by works” tell me about how God sees me?
- Did Christ die for me when I was productive or when I was a sinner?
- What does Zephaniah say God does over me?
- How would my days look different if I believed I was already loved?
- What would I do from love instead of for approval?

Truth summary

> God values me because I am His, not because of what I accomplish. His love was given while I was still a sinner. I can work and serve from love, not for approval.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Grace
- Love, By God
- Salvation
- Self-Esteem, Low
- God, All Loving

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Self-Esteem, Low
- Love

Listen: Overcoming Depression

> Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

This Is Amazing Grace — Phil Wickham
Christ bears the burden of rescue rather than demanding self-salvation.

Jesus Loves Me — Gaither Vocal Band
This familiar hymn places confidence in Jesus’ love rather than personal strength.

Is He Worthy — Andrew Peterson
Honest recognition of a broken world can lead to hope in Christ’s final restoration.

Amazing Grace — Reawaken Hymns
This classic hymn locates salvation and sustaining hope in grace rather than merit.

Each morning ask: “If I truly believed God’s truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?”

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "God values me for what I accomplish"

✦ ✦ ✦

Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"God values me for what I accomplish." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ When was I praised for what I did?
- ☐ What does "not by works" mean for me?
- ☐ How does God feel about me on a bad day?
- ☐ What does Zephaniah 3:17 say?
- ☐ What would I do from love?
- ☐ What can I do quietly for no reward?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ I am saved by grace, not works.
- ☐ God proved His love while I was a sinner.
- ☐ My name is written in heaven.
- ☐ He rejoices over me with singing.
- ☐ My worth does not rise and fall with results.
- ☐ I can serve from love.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ Ephesians 2:8–9
  "For it is by grace you have been saved through faith, and this not from yourselves; it is the gift of God, not by works, so that no one can boast."
- ☐ Romans 5:8
  "But God proves His love for us in this: While we were still sinners, Christ died for us."
- ☐ Zephaniah 3:17
  "The LORD your God is among you; He is mighty to save. He will rejoice over you with gladness; He will quiet you with His love; He will rejoice over you with singing."

A verse I found myself: _____

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

Practicing the Truth

✦ ✦ ✦

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PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- ☐ Loved before doing: Each morning, say "I am loved before I do anything today," and note one task done from love.
- ☐ My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, Ephesians 2:8–9 becomes: "Sarah can write: "I am saved by grace, not by works, so God's love does not depend on what I accomplish.""
- ☐ Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- ☐ Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
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6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

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- ☐ Trace the message. Write who taught you that love is earned.
- ☐ Read Zephaniah 3:17. Imagine God singing over you, not tallying your day.
- ☐ Separate worth and work. Write one sentence that distinguishes who you are from what you do.
- ☐ Do one thing for no reward. Serve quietly, without anyone knowing.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "God values me for what I accomplish": _____ % My truth: _____ %

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My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~God values me for what I accomplish.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Father, thank You for loving me before I did anything. Free me from trying to earn what You have already given. Help me work and serve from love, resting in Your delight in me. Amen.

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